

By M.G. Radhakrishnan

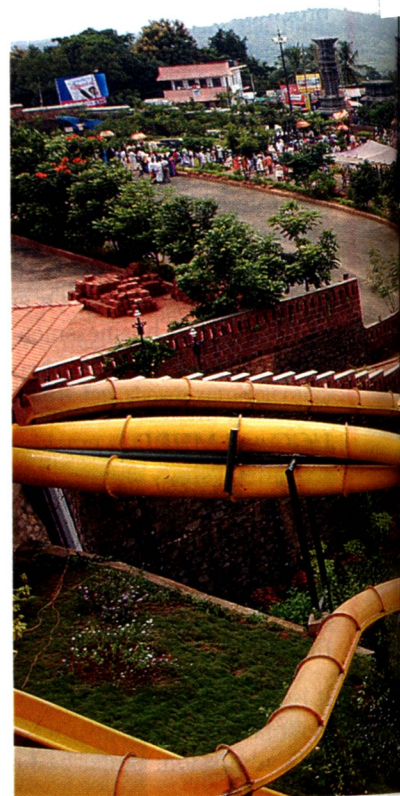
Kannur, at the northern tip of Kerala, is also known as "Kerala's Yenan" because that is where the state's Communist party was born seven decades ago. Hundreds of martyr's columns and hammer and sickle memorials to comrades killed in uprisings and political clashes greet visitors to this red bastion. But the hoary icons that have been identified with the party for long may soon be outnumbered by a radically different kind. And the new Left leitmotifs? Hold your breath. They are amusement parks, eco-tourism projects, multi-speciality

hospitals, five-star resorts, IMAX theatres and wax museums.

The latest capitalist venture of the CPI(M) is the aptly named Malabar Pleasures Private Ltd. whose objective is to establish amusement and water theme parks, hotels, restaurants, motels, cool bars, handicraft shops, river cruises, hill and beach resorts. Among these new-age Left projects, the Vismaya Amusement and Water Theme Park and Mangroves Eco-Tourism projects have already been commissioned in Kannur's red heartland, Pappinisseri. An IMAX theatre and wax museum are among those coming up in the proposed memorial being built for the late former

From Marx TO IMAX

With a defeat staring them in the face in next year's polls, the self-styled guardians of the working class are turning to business, running amusement parks and star resorts



chief minister E.K. Nayanar, a stalwart of Kannur Communism.

The CPI(M)'s critics, both inside and outside the Left, are appalled. "These are the concrete memorials for the new CPI(M)'s complete capitulation to the corporate and neo-liberal culture," laments a prominent Left wing writer. Many party old timers in Kannur and elsewhere have raised distress signals about the bourgeois symbols in the party. The Opposition United Democratic Front has dubbed the amassment of assets like these and scores of buildings being built across the state for party's and its feeder organisations as blatant corruption and naked misuse of power. "The CPI(M) is the most corrupt and richest party in the country. Its assets in the state alone are worth Rs 4,000 crore," charges